

share of the planet's social life, and infrastructure at that scale doesn't get to stay likeable forever.

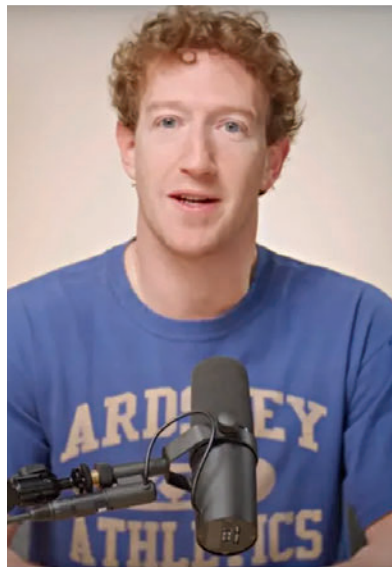
## The turn

Here's where the second half of the Dark Knight quote kicks in. The same scale that made Zuckerberg a hero is exactly what made the fall so visible, and so hard to walk back from. Cambridge Analytica in 2018 wasn't really about one rogue data firm harvesting profiles for political targeting. It exposed that Facebook's entire growth model ran on collecting personal data with a level of consent that was, charitably, theoretical. The FTC fined Meta five billion dollars in 2019, at the time the largest privacy penalty ever issued against a company, and the stock barely flinched. Congress hauled Zuckerberg in for testimony so many times that his stiff, lawyer-coached answers became their own genre of internet meme.

The breaches kept stacking up after that too. A 2021 leak exposed personal data from more than five hundred million accounts, scraped years earlier through a vulnerability the company had supposedly patched. Internal research later surfaced through whistleblower disclosures showing Meta had data linking Instagram to body image harm and anxiety in teenage girls, and had largely sat on it rather than act. That's the detail that turned abstract "privacy concerns" into the multistate lawsuits over child safety that are still working their way through US courts, and it's the one allegation in this whole story that's hardest to file under "growing pains."

Then there's the rebrand. Renaming the company Meta in 2021 and committing tens of billions of dollars to a Metaverse nobody had asked for was Zuckerberg's most expensive attempt to author the next narrative instead of reacting to the current one. It mostly produced awkward legless avatars and a punchline that outlived

the product roadmap. He's since quietly redirected that same appetite for big, expensive bets into AI, where Meta is now being sued by author Scott Turow alongside five major publishing houses, with the complaint alleging Zuckerberg personally authorized training the Llama models on pirated books after the company considered and then abandoned licensing deals. The pattern hasn't really changed in twenty years. Move fast, build the thing, deal with the lawsuit on the other side of it.



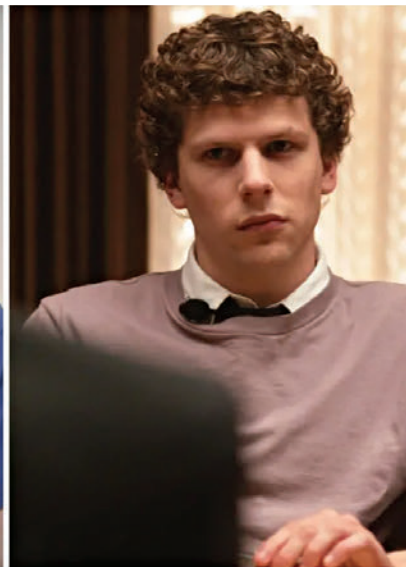
## The Social Network problem

David Fincher's *The Social Network* turned Zuckerberg into a cultural character before Zuckerberg himself had finished becoming one, a socially awkward genius who builds something massive out of equal parts ambition and resentment, betraying a co-founder and getting sued by twin brothers along the way. He's said in interviews that the film took serious liberties, that the founding involved a lot more spreadsheets and a lot less personal betrayal than the script suggested. But the image stuck for a reason that has nothing to do with accuracy. It's the same hero-villain duality the Dark Knight line captures,

just told a decade earlier, through a courtroom deposition instead of a Senate hearing room. Hollywood essentially pre-wrote his second act before he'd lived it.

## The unfinished verdict

What makes Zuckerberg's story different from someone like Travis Kalanick or Sam Bankman-Fried is that he never actually got removed from his own narrative. No board coup, no exile, no forced redemption arc, because he never left the building in



the first place. He's still CEO. He still controls Meta through supervoting shares that no lawsuit, shareholder revolt, or congressional hearing has managed to touch. And he's still making the exact same bet he made in a Harvard dorm room in 2004, that connecting people at scale is worth whatever reputational cost comes with how you went about doing it.

Whether that adds up to heroism that curdled with age, or villainy that was the design all along and just took two decades to become visible, depends on which decade you're judging him by. He's not done with the next one, and history hasn't finished delivering the final verdict on him. **T**